

## PART ONE

# Develop a Leader Mindset





# 1.

# The Transition to Leadership

When you become a manager, it isn't just your title and responsibilities that change. Your idea of work and your identity evolve, too. As an individual contributor, you focused on your contribution to your team. As a leader, you have to navigate a complex new landscape of authority to help *others* do their best, too.

This journey is one of the most significant you'll experience in your professional life, an exciting opportunity that comes with challenges, too. Management represents a major departure from what you've done in the past, and what made you successful so far won't necessarily help you advance now. To stand out from the pack, you must understand the nature of your new role as a manager *and* a leader, and prepare yourself for the changes and stress that can accompany this period of intense growth.

## Understanding your role as a manager

At its most basic level, your role as a manager is to set direction for your team and coordinate resources to meet your organization's goals. Your boss

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and your direct reports all have different expectations about what aspects of this work are most important. Your supervisor may emphasize planning and resource management, supporting corporate goals, managing risk, and accepting final accountability for your unit. Your employees likely have a different view: they look to you to organize and direct the group's strategic goals, support them as they accomplish tasks, solve problems, and answer questions decisively, and facilitate their long-term growth.

As for your own expectations, you've spent years watching other managers and being managed by them. Along the way, you probably picked up plenty of ideas about how to do this *right* (and certain ideas about what *wrong* looks like, too). But as an individual contributor, you only saw a small part of your boss's life. How she thought about her role and the way she interacted with peers, supervisors, and contacts outside the company weren't entirely visible to you. So as you navigate these experiences for yourself, you may need to overcome two common misperceptions.

### ***People versus tasks***

When you were an individual contributor, success meant completing specific assignments: making a sales call, for example, or designing a prototype. You may naturally assume that you'll continue to use these same skills as a new manager. But now your job is to help your direct reports do these activities on their own. You coach the salesperson who makes the call or secure resources for the designer who's working on the prototype. Your purpose has shifted from *doing tasks* to *developing and directing people*.

This shift may feel counterintuitive. You once had the best sales record on the team, and now you're watching a less experienced person struggle with your old accounts. Resist the urge to show the person how *you* used to do it; your own mastery isn't the point. Instead, you must help others thrive and develop their own competencies, redefining your own success to include that of the people on your team.

### ***Personal influence versus positional authority***

New managers also often expect that their title will make it easier for them to implement their ideas and are surprised to find that the opposite is true.

Managers have formal authority to make decisions, allocate resources, and direct employees—in theory. In actuality, though, people won't do something just because you tell them to, and they certainly won't do it well. Although you can use your positional authority to force compliance, your team members won't commit fully or deliver their best work under these conditions. You also won't benefit from the value of their perspective.

Assuming a position of power means you must become *more* responsive to the needs of your direct reports and the demands of your organization. You can't simply announce a new professional development plan to your team; you also need to persuade them to take it seriously. You can't just decide on a budget for your division; you also need to convince the executive team to allocate the funds.

By contrast, when you exercise influence, your people act because they find you personally persuasive—your character, your competence, your words or actions. You're not making them do something. They're choosing to do it because you are leading them effectively. That willingness makes all the difference. It means they're more likely to put forth their best effort, and that you're more likely to achieve higher levels of team performance.

To get to this point, you must meet your direct reports where they are and engage their preexisting motivations. Down the line, your actions will create a deep well of trust that will allow you to influence your employees' behaviors, attitudes, and values. This is where your real power lies: not in your job description but inside relationships, in the reciprocal interactions of ordinary office dynamics and politics. We'll talk about this more in chapter 2, "Building Trust and Credibility," and chapter 5, "Becoming a Person of Influence."

## The difference between management and leadership

We've already used the terms "leader" and "manager," but what's the difference? This topic has been the subject of much debate since Harvard Business School (HBS) professor Abraham Zaleznik published a *Harvard Business Review* article in 1977 titled "Managers and Leaders: Are They

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Different?” The piece caused an uproar in business schools. It argued that the theoreticians of scientific management, with their organizational diagrams and time-and-motion studies, were missing half the picture—the half filled with inspiration, vision, and messy human nature. This, Zaleznik argued, was truly what leadership was about.

As HBS professor John Kotter later argued, *management* is about responding to complexity. To get a job done, managers must focus on control and predictability, and they must organize processes that will produce orderly outcomes. Planning, budgeting, and staffing are all management activities. When you draw up task assignments, for example, or discuss optimizing a production line, you’re wearing the manager hat.

*Leadership*, by contrast, explains Kotter, is about producing and responding to change. Leaders see opportunities in the instabilities that their managerial alter egos want to tame, and they emphasize ideas over process. Setting direction, aligning people, and providing motivation are all leadership activities. When you coach a star employee or decide to halt your production optimization process because it’s just not working, that’s leadership.

Kotter argues that management and leadership are complementary modes of being and need not be in conflict. The most successful managers in today’s challenging business environment leverage both management and leadership competencies selectively to benefit the organization. In this book, we’ll use the words somewhat interchangeably, preferring “manager” for technical and administrative topics and “leader” for issues that touch on vision, strategy, and motivation.

While your company determines when and how you transition to management, opportunities for leadership can present themselves at any time in your career. That’s because leadership doesn’t always require formal authority, but rather an array of intellectual and interpersonal skills.

### Demystifying leadership

Although management and leadership are deeply intertwined in practice, we have long put the *idea* of leadership on a higher plane. We often view

it as requiring a set of innate traits: intelligence, self-confidence, vision, eloquence, and a mystical blend of courage, charisma, and decisiveness. Those individuals with all of these traits were deemed “born leaders.” But as science has revealed the plasticity of the human brain, we no longer think about these qualities as inborn or fixed. Instead we see leadership as a constellation of skills that can be learned and capacities that can be nurtured over time. In other words: just because you weren’t senior class president doesn’t mean you’ll never be a leader.

This also means you’ll integrate leadership abilities into your personality differently from your peers, depending on your underlying disposition. If you are more of an introvert, for example, you may be more eloquent in writing than in spontaneous conversation. But many of the markers we used to take as shorthand for “good leader” are irrelevant or incorrect. For example:

- Leaders don’t just work in the C-suite. Leaders are everywhere, and at every level.
- No one “looks” like a leader. Your gender, race, age, height, and the like are utterly immaterial.
- Extroverts aren’t more effective leaders than introverts.
- Leaders aren’t always hyperconfident in their judgment. You can change your mind and experience uncertainty.
- Leaders are as likely to be listening as talking.

Right now you already have some of the characteristics of a strong leader. Instead of burdening yourself with the question “Am I a leader?” push yourself to identify these abilities and capitalize on them. Using the list in the box “Common leadership traits,” assess which of your leadership traits are most valuable in your organization’s culture. Then think about your own self-image as a leader and how you want others to see you. This will help you identify what strengths to leverage and where you have an opportunity to improve in your new role and over the course of your career.

## Common leadership traits

### INTELLECTUAL

- **Informed.** Are you knowledgeable and well informed about your industry, your business, and your priorities?
- **Future-focused.** Do you organize short-term tasks according to long-term priorities?
- **Decisive.** Do you make decisions even though all the facts are not available? Can you make difficult trade-offs?
- **Comfortable with ambiguity.** Can you operate in uncertain environments with few dependable guideposts? Do you adapt well to change?

### SOCIO-EMOTIONAL

- **Self-aware.** Do you pay attention to how your behavior affects others?
- **Engaged.** Do you empathize with other people's needs, concerns, and goals?
- **Steady.** Do you maintain a positive, focused perspective and continue to lead during turmoil and confusion?
- **Trustworthy.** Are your actions consistent with your values? Do you keep promises?

### ORGANIZATIONAL

- **Collaborative.** Do you work well and frequently with your boss, your peers, and your team members to deliver outstanding collective results?
- **Influential.** Do you listen closely, find common ground, and express yourself clearly to persuade and drive influence outcomes in the organization?



- **Politically astute.** Do you understand your organization's power structure? Do you grasp how key players think? Do you know where to turn for support and resources?
- **Stimulating.** Do you challenge the status quo? Do you convince others to set high standards and stretch goals?

Your title makes you a manager, but whether you become a leader as well is up to you. Leadership “is something you need to work at versus a state of being or a destination,” former HBS professor Robert Steven Kaplan explains; developing these traits is an ongoing practice.

## Handling the emotional challenges of the transition

As you begin your work as a manager, you'll experience a mix of emotions, including intense feelings of excitement, pride, anxiety, and loneliness. At times, it may feel like emotional whiplash. Let's look at two examples:

- A new branch manager described the feeling to HBS professor Linda Hill “Do you know how hard it is to be the boss when you are so out of control? It's the feeling you get when you have a child . . . [A]ll of a sudden you're a mother or a father and you're supposed to know everything there is to know about taking care of a kid.” That kind of stark shift can be tough to handle.
- Management consultant Carol Walker describes a former client—“smart, thoughtful, forward thinking, resourceful”—who admitted he was completely overwhelmed after six months in a new managerial position. “He had started to doubt his own abilities,” Walker writes. “He looked like a deer in the headlights.”

This kind of performance anxiety can be particularly unsettling if you're coming off a string of successes as an individual contributor. Self-doubt crops up in new situations, and old coping mechanisms may no longer apply.

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But these feelings are perfectly normal, and they will resolve naturally over time as your skills and confidence grow. In the meantime, handle the situation in the moment by identifying the emotion and its source, and in the longer term, by taking care of your health and work-life balance.

### ***Step 1: Label your emotions***

First, label what you're feeling. Just the act of naming the emotion—"I'm feeling anxiety right now"—can help you moderate your response. Here are some common examples:

- **Performance anxiety.** "I'm afraid I can't do this job."
- **Regret.** "Why did I even take this job to begin with?"
- **Frustration.** "I keep making mistakes" or "Things keep going wrong."
- **Humility.** "I'm not as ready for this job as I thought."
- **Loss.** "I miss the identity, camaraderie, and sense of competence I had in my old job."
- **Confusion.** "I'm not sure where I fit in here anymore."

### ***Step 2: Find the source and a solution***

Once you understand *what* you're feeling, consider *where* it's coming from. What are the causes of your stress? Your answer can help you identify new ways to cope with or mitigate the problem. There are four common sources of stress for new and developing managers: role strain, problem-solving fatigue, isolation, and imposter syndrome. Each has its own symptoms—and concrete solutions (see the box "Four sources of stress").

### ***Take care of yourself***

All of these coping mechanisms are strategies you can use to deal with emotional stresses as they arise. Ideally, though, you wouldn't have to wait for a crisis to act. What preventative measures can you take to keep yourself on an even keel during the transition? We'll talk more about work-life

## Four sources of stress

### ROLE STRAIN

You face conflict, ambiguity, and overload in your position.

#### *Symptoms*

- You have too much work and too little time, information, and resources, like the rookie manager in the example in the box “Voices: Struggling to find time for important work.”
- You have conflicting responsibilities, like increasing revenues and reducing costs.
- You answer to too many people: direct reports, peers, supervisors, and customers pull you in multiple directions.

#### *Solutions*

- Create quiet, regular periods during your day for uninterrupted work. Pick tasks on which you can make good headway and protect this time from interruption.
- Acknowledge your deficiencies. You can't be an expert on everything, so find people you can depend on to do the things you can't.
- Embrace imperfection. You can't meet every demand that's made of you. Use your best judgment, negotiate priorities as needed, and be adaptive in the aftermath.

### PROBLEM-SOLVING FATIGUE

You feel pressure to solve difficult problems for other people.

#### *Symptoms*

- You feel overwhelmed by the problems your direct reports bring to you.
- You're dismayed that employees aren't meeting the standards to which you held yourself as an individual contributor.

*(continued)*

- You manage problem employees who provoke your anger, fear, anxiety, and frustration.

### **Solutions**

- Draw boundaries around what kinds of problems you'll take on.
- Coach direct reports on how to solve more problems on their own. For example, ask your employee to email you a summary of possible solutions to their problem and a recommendation for how to proceed.
- Resist the urge to classify everyone who comes to you with concerns as a problem employee. Develop a physical cue to ground yourself in difficult interactions.

### **ISOLATION**

You mourn the loss of your old work life and are acclimating to a new social distance in the office.

### **Symptoms**

- You don't have a clear group whose values and norms you identify with, like the lonely manager in "Voices: Looking for a confidant."
- You must make unpopular decisions, and people are reacting with mistrust and resentment.
- You no longer have casual social contact with your former peers now that they're your subordinates.

### **Solutions**

- Seek support and companionship from other people in your organization, especially past coworkers who don't report to you. For example, set up lunch with a colleague, maybe another manager who was promoted at the same time as you.

- Develop new routines for making social contact with your team. Check in with a different person each morning as you settle in for the day, or host a regular midweek afternoon coffee break for the whole office.

## **IMPOSTER SYNDROME**

You feel chronically inadequate and struggle to conceal the fact from others.

### ***Symptoms***

- You're afraid to make or acknowledge mistakes because you think that showing weakness will diminish your power.
- You worry that you aren't a good role model because everyone can see how stressed you are.
- You fear that your direct reports' failures reflect on you.
- You feel uncomfortable with the amount of power you have over other people's lives.

### ***Solutions***

- Show some vulnerability. Share openly what you know, but also where you need more information. Seek out assistance from those who can help. Provide assistance in return.
- Admit your mistakes. Honesty isn't a weakness: it makes you more approachable and credible.
- Focus on behaviors. Instead of fixating on anxious feelings, formulate specific actions that give you a sense of control over a stressful situation. For example, plan what you'll say next time you're feeling overwhelmed, so that no matter how flustered or annoyed you are, you can gracefully own your actions or exit a situation and recoup.

## VOICES

## Struggling to find time for important work

I recently worked with a young manager who had become so accustomed to responding to a steady flow of problems that he was reluctant to block off any time to work on the strategic initiatives we had identified. When I probed, he revealed that he felt a critical part of his role was to wait for crises to arise. “What if I schedule this time and something urgent comes up and I disappoint someone?” he asked. When I pointed out that he could always postpone his strategy sessions if a true emergency arose, he seemed relieved.

Source: Carol A. Walker, “Saving Your Rookie Managers from Themselves,” *Harvard Business Review*, April 2002.

balance for the long term in chapter 7, “Personal Productivity,” but it’s particularly important to focus on prevention as you take on the stress of a new role:

- **Don’t neglect your personal life.** Cutting yourself off from a support network triggers a nasty feedback loop of emotional stress and poor performance. Friends and family can listen to what you’re going through and reconnect you with the parts of your life—and yourself—that make you feel good.
- **Protect your downtime.** Stress takes a mental and physical toll: your brain needs a break, and so does your body. Give yourself a day, or even a half day, off occasionally and spend the time doing whatever activities you find most rejuvenating.
- **Take care of your health.** Don’t skip meals, and carve out time for an exercise regime. Most importantly, try to get enough sleep.

## VOICES

### Looking for a confidant

I used to be fascinated by the insights of an acquaintance who acted as sounding board/father confessor to some of the top names in British industry. As director of a corporate intelligence firm, he became privy to the fears and concerns of CEOs and senior directors, usually men over the age of 55. And although he was very discreet, he said that one thing united these powerful men, regardless of their industry or background: loneliness at the top.

I was always curious about how he managed to get these executives to open up about these feelings of loneliness. His answer was novel: more often than not, he said, the main photograph on their desk didn't show their wife or their children, but their pet dog: "The only one they could really tell everything."

Source: Gill Corkindale, "How Engaged a Leader Are You?," HBR.org, March 17, 2008.

Chronic sleep deprivation impairs your thinking and puts you at higher risk for a host of medical problems, from heart attacks to depression.

- **Keep your job in perspective.** When work feels as if it's spinning out of control, recenter yourself by asking, "What's most important to me? What really counts in life?" Nothing is worth your sanity, your physical health, or your family and friends. Compromising those parts of your life won't solve your problems; it will only make you more vulnerable to a major collapse.

All new managers struggle to cope with the feelings that accompany their new responsibilities, and the truth is that this struggle never really goes away. Even experienced managers wrestle with problems like role strain and imposter syndrome, especially when events at work or at home

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put them under extra stress. So it's important to learn to recognize these strains and be kind to yourself as you develop your own strategies for managing them.

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The first six to twelve months of your new role will be a whirlwind of new experiences. As you grow rapidly as a manager and a leader, you'll find yourself doing things you'd never thought you'd do. Some will be mundane, like helping an employee find a better desk away from the air-conditioning vent; and some others will be exhilarating or terrifying in their enormity, such as pitching a new direction for R&D, supporting a coworker through a health crisis, or going all in with your team to keep your warehouse operating during a bad storm. You'll only get to make this transition, with all its highs and lows, once in your life, but the journey of leadership will last for your whole career.

### Recap

- Your role as a manager is to set direction for your team and coordinate resources to meet your organization's goals. Your employees and your boss may have different expectations for what you should accomplish as a manager.
- The nature of your work changes when you go from an individual contributor to a manager, from *doing tasks* to *developing and directing people*.
- As you adapt to this new way of working, don't rely too heavily on your positional authority to compel action from your direct reports. Instead, focus on developing personal influence.
- Management and leadership are different, but complementary, practices. As you grow into this role, you'll strive to be both a manager and a leader in your organization.



- Leadership is a learnable skill set, and there's no single template for it, though there are common skills you can learn. Developing your leadership abilities can be a lifelong journey, but you can exhibit leadership at any point in your career.

## Action items

- ☐ Understand where you are on your leadership path by exploring the questions in "Common Leadership Traits."
- ☐ Reflect on the emotions you are experiencing in your managerial role. What might be their source? Use the list of potential solutions to identify ways to manage your response.
- ☐ Consider your routines for exercise, family mealtimes, and sleep. If you don't have healthy habits in place, begin experimenting with better ways to take care of yourself. If you do, reinforce your intention to keep doing them as you step into your new role.





## 2.

# Building Trust and Credibility

One of your first tasks as a manager and leader is to gain the trust of your team. But your employees won't grant that trust automatically. As a manager, you have a profound effect on how they do their work and live their professional lives. As you take charge, they will have questions such as: Will you be able to represent their work well to people outside the unit? Is it safe to speak up when they disagree with you? How will you react when they tell you they've made a mistake? What values will you act on when faced with a difficult decision? Will you be an ally and an advocate?

Gaining trust can be a particularly delicate task when you have been promoted to manage your former peers. You need to establish authority and credibility without alienating those who used to have the same title as you—or who may even have been vying for the same job—and whose allegiance you now need. See the box “Tips: How to manage your former peers.”

Harvard Business School professor Linda Hill and executive coach Kent Lineback define trust as a combination of two components: *character* and *competence*. Character is about how your intentions align with your actions,

## TIPS

## How to manage your former peers

If you've been promoted over your former coworkers, you have a fine line to walk. Here's how to get off on the right foot.

- **Make people aware of the transition.** Ideally the team will learn about your promotion from someone else—the outgoing boss or another supervisor. Make sure there's a plan in place for getting the word out, and if you end up making the announcement yourself, be modest with the wording.
- **Don't introduce any major changes right away.** No matter how good your plan is, hold off for a bit. Aggressive change will look like a rejection of your predecessor, and you don't know how their supporters will feel about that. Don't damage these relationships right off the bat.
- **Meet with your team members one-on-one.** Don't let people form assumptions about what your new relationship with them will be like; *show* them. Spend time with each person, individually and in small groups, sharing your vision and asking for feedback. "What can I do to support your success?" is a great lead-in.
- **Distance yourself.** If you continue to socialize with people the way you used to, you'll blur the lines that define your new role and open yourself to the accusation that you're playing favorites.
- **Make peace with your rivals.** If you competed for this job with peers, acknowledge to yourself that they've suffered a loss. Don't go overboard—it will look like you're gloating—but pull them aside to say that you value their contributions. If you can, take a specific action to back up your words, like assigning them an important task.

Source: Amy Gallo, "How to Manage Your Former Peers," HBR.org, December 2012.

while competence refers to the technical, operational, and political knowledge you bring to the job. Your employees quickly form opinions of your character and competence based on both what you say and what you do, and they'll continue to refine these opinions as they get to know you better.

## Establishing your character

Your *character* is about your values: Are you out only for your own gain, or the company's profit? Do you also genuinely care about the group? If you don't, Hill and Lineback warn, your people will not trust your character, no matter how able and productive you are. Demonstrate your interest in the group and its work in the following ways:

### Strive for consistency.

Being consistent means that your actions align with the values you profess. For example, if you emphasize rigor and accuracy to your team, you also vet your own information carefully and invite them to question your conclusions. Keep your promises and model ethical behavior from day one, even if it means making an unpopular decision, like reassigning a well-liked employee who has a conflict of interest. By behaving consistently, you teach people that they can interpret your actions in a straightforward way, without worrying about your intentions.

### Regulate your emotions.

Your employees don't need to you to be a beam of sunshine in the office, but they do need to know that you won't have a meltdown or lash out when you're under a lot of stress. Avoid extreme emotional displays like giddiness and despair, and show compassion for others when you're in a tough situation. For more about how to cultivate this quality, see "Emotional steadiness and self control" in chapter 3, "Emotional Intelligence."

### Mind your manners.

Show respect for people as individuals. Be respectful by about answering emails promptly and beginning and ending meetings on time. Say hello

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to people in the hallways, hold the elevator door, make eye contact when you're listening, and don't multitask during meetings. Pay attention to the message you're sending with more subtle body language, too. Research by Northeastern University professor David DeSteno shows that people are likely to perceive you as untrustworthy when you clasp your hands, touch your face, cross your arms, or lean away from a conversation.

### **Ask questions.**

You can get a lot of mileage out of a question. It solicits information, but it also *communicates* information—about who you are, what you care about, and how you regard the person you're talking to. Good questions demonstrate your own knowledge and values, and by listening attentively, you show people that you're interested in who they are and what they can do. This tactic is especially useful when you're new to a team and you don't want to come off as arrogant or close-minded.

### **Invite feedback.**

Show that you care about your impact on others by asking people for feedback and then doing something with it. The point here isn't just to become a better manager, but to demonstrate self-awareness. Everyone has blind spots, so show that you're willing to take responsibility for yours.

### **Give others a chance to shine.**

Prove to your employees that you genuinely welcome their input by actually using their knowledge in early decision making and problem solving. Recognize individual contributions, not just within your office but to the rest of the company, too. Show that you want their efforts to benefit *them* directly, and that they can trust you to steward their good work without trying to take advantage of it. By soliciting—and crediting—help from your team, you send the message that you don't just see them as drones or instruments to your own triumph.

Note that these strategies don't have anything to do with being likable. If your sense of humor doesn't connect with that of one of your employ-

ees, that's OK. What matters is their perception of your integrity, that you mean well by them and by the company, and that you can deliver on your promises.

## **Demonstrating your competence**

As your employees evaluate your character, they're also taking stock of your competence. On their minds are questions such as:

- Do you understand the work your unit performs? Do you know how this work gets done in your organization?
- Do you know how to get the resources and visibility your team members need to be successful?
- Are you an effective coach and developer of talent in the organization?

Your employees will find the answers to these questions in your everyday behavior as well. Here's how you can cultivate their faith in your competence:

### **Plan quick wins when you start a new role.**

Ultimately, people are going to judge you by your results. So produce some good ones—fast. In his classic work on the “first ninety days” of any new management role, leadership transitions expert Michael Watkins recommends picking three or four simple, well-defined problems that matter to your team or your boss and solving them in a way that's consistent with company culture. Don't overreach: failing at five tasks looks worse than succeeding at four.

### **Confront tough issues and knock down roadblocks.**

Your employees want to know whether you have the operational and political know-how to create favorable conditions for their work in the organization at large. Identify a few of the obstacles that are holding your team back: Can you get a famously difficult executive to sign off on a resource

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request? Can you persuade other business unit heads to untangle a project plan that's gone to seed? Succeed with these outsiders, and your team will know you can get things done.

### **Research your ideas.**

To build a credible position, talk with people inside and outside your organization. Review articles and research reports. Then talk about it with your team—in meetings, in the elevator, over email. As a manager, you're open to the criticism that you don't know what's *really* going on or that you don't care about the experience of the front liners. Counter this suspicion by spending a morning shadowing your delivery crew, for example, or sitting in with your engineers as they work through a bug. Show that you want to see what they see and make your desire to both learn and share information visible.

### **Explain your decisions and actions.**

Be explicit about the motivations and values that drive you and lay out your decision-making process. Don't worry about overjustifying your actions; instead, focus on communicating your expertise and sense of the larger organizational context. These conversations are especially helpful when you're new to a group and looking for opportunities to introduce yourself to everyone. But keep your explanations tightly focused on the issue at hand, so that you don't wander into an irrelevant discourse on every single one of your credentials.

### **Be honest about what you do and don't know.**

It never pays to fake knowledge. If it turns out you're wrong, at best you'll just look silly, and at worst, you'll cause a serious problem for the rest of the group. Ask for clarification when you need it and listen more than you talk. Don't make a big show of your expertise, either. You'll look insecure and invite unhealthy competition from your subordinates. You demonstrate confidence by engaging others openly to expand your knowledge.



**Arrange for backup.**

Your team might not trust you yet, so whom *do* they trust? Find the people whose opinions matter in your field and show that they support you. Cite sources like an industry journal, get an endorsement from a guru inside your own company, or hire an independent specialist. Their credibility will augment your own and show that you're willing to commit real resources to success. Their presence will be especially powerful if their expertise is in something you acknowledge isn't your strength.

**Ask others to test your idea's merit.**

You probably know what it's like to work for someone who falls in love with their own ideas and won't entertain criticism, or who pushes their ideas too far, too fast. Show that you welcome new input and want to test your ideas thoroughly.

Making a deliberate effort to gain others' trust may feel awkward at first, or even manipulative. But remember, the goal isn't to convince people that you're somebody you're not; instead, you're trying to show them who you really are. And that's worth some time and thought, as you'll see.

**Cultivating authentic leadership**

"People trust you when you are genuine and authentic, not a replica of someone else," writes Bill George, former chairman and CEO of Medtronic and a professor at Harvard Business School. George and his coauthors popularized this concept as "authentic leadership," arguing that the most effective leaders make their work a deeply personal endeavor. They act from passion and according to their values, and they bring about change by building open, meaningful relationships with people in their organization, who grow to trust them deeply. That trust comes from recognizing a real person behind the mask of power, someone who wears their motives and

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values and goals in the open for all to see. This authenticity is an important component of showing strong character.

Authentic leaders develop their individual styles through trial and error. To explore and develop your own authentic leadership:

### **Learn from your life story.**

Discovering your own origin story will supply purpose and inspiration in your future. Your values and goals come from somewhere. Connecting your present self with past experiences will deepen your understanding of why you see the world the way you do and why you care about the things that matter to you. Examine your history and learn to articulate your story and share it freely.

### **Understand your extrinsic and intrinsic motivations.**

Extrinsic motivations are the external outcomes you seek: recognition, status, wealth, and so on. Intrinsic motivations are rewards internal to the self: personal growth, for example, or the satisfaction of helping others. All leaders will acknowledge that extrinsic factors play a big role in their thinking, but it's important to understand how your work interacts with your internal sense of meaning, too. Once you identify these motivations, you can look for opportunities to nurture them.

### **Foster self-awareness.**

It can be painful to accept feedback from colleagues and be transparent about your own shortcomings in turn. You have to open yourself to the judgments of others—people you supervise, collaborate and compete with, and want to impress. If you don't know how other people see you, any negative information, however minor, is devastating. The more clearly you understand the impression you make on others, the better you'll be at processing criticism. (You'll learn more about the power of self-awareness in chapter 3, "Emotional Intelligence.")

Complete the prompts in the box "Developing yourself as an authentic leader" to begin thinking about how you can be more authentic in your management and leadership.

While authentic leadership is a worthy goal, a simplistic understanding of the concept can lead you astray. If we adhere too strongly to what we are already comfortable doing or being, we lose the opportunity to grow in new ways, according to INSEAD professor Herminia Ibarra.

As your professional life unfolds and you confront new experiences, Ibarra explains, you need to retain a flexible sense of self. Imagine you've

## Developing yourself as an authentic leader

Authentic leadership pushes you to reflect on your identity and your purpose in life. Here are some questions to guide you through this exercise.

1. **Which people and experiences in your early life had the greatest impact on you?** What impact did they have?
2. **How do you cultivate self-awareness daily?** What are the moments when you say to yourself, *this is the real me*?
3. **What are your most deeply held values?** Where did they come from? Have your values changed significantly since your childhood? How do your values inform your actions?
4. **What motivates you, extrinsically and intrinsically?** How do you balance these motivations in your life?
5. **What kind of support network do you have?** How does your team ground you as a leader? How should you diversify your team to broaden your perspective?
6. **Is your life integrated?** Are you able to be the same person in all aspects of your life—personal, work, family, and community? If not, what's holding you back?
7. **What does being authentic mean in your life?** Are you more effective as a leader when you behave authentically? Have you ever paid a price for your authenticity, and was it worth it?

Source: Adapted from Bill George, Peter Sims, Andrew N. McLean, and Diana Mayer, "Discovering Your Authentic Leadership," *Harvard Business Review*, February 2007.

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worked your way up in an organization that values the chain of command. What happens when you start a new job at an organization with a more collaborative, discursive decision-making culture? Do you stay true to your “authentic” self and keep deploying a command-and-control style of leadership? Or do you push yourself to try to succeed within the new firm’s culture, even if it feels fake at first?

To become a leader, you must, to some extent, shape and create a *new* identity for yourself. Give yourself permission to experiment with novel ways of working and of managing, even if they feel uncomfortable. You’re not pretending to be a different person: rather, your new experiences are genuinely transforming you. What originally feels uncomfortable may end up becoming a significant moment in your personal growth.

But while you must remain open to change, you don’t necessarily need to open up to everyone else about it. Avoid being too candid about the insecurity you may feel as you face new management problems or try out new leadership styles. If you’re too rigid about personal transparency (“Folks, I’ve never owned a P&L before and I have no idea what I’m doing!”), you’ll undermine your own development. Allow yourself to project self-assurance even when you don’t feel like a natural. Trying on that sense of confidence may be the first step toward making it real.

## Ethics and integrity

Finally, as discussed earlier, demonstrating ethical behavior is also important to establishing your team’s trust in your character. It’s also an important part of your role as a manager. Business ethics is a set of norms about what right behavior looks like in the workplace and how you should navigate the many conflicts that may arise between the interests of stakeholders like customers, workers, management, investors, the general public, and so on. It extends into every part of your work, intersecting with your legal responsibilities (to comply with all laws and regulations) and your fiscal responsibilities (to create wealth for the company and profits for the shareholder, for example).

In the past, consideration of ethics was the province of a company's human resources department, general counsel's office, and senior management. That's no longer the case: it's now a primary duty of frontline managers. In many business schools, ethics is taught as one of the core responsibilities of all managers. It's an obligation you hold to your company and its shareholders, but also toward the people you manage. At the simplest level, your ethical position determines whether they feel safe in your organization—from harassment and assault by customers or colleagues, for example. And even minor ethical failures can do serious damage to office morale. If your people don't trust you to set the right tone, they can't contribute freely. Instead, they'll hold back their best work out of fear and self-protection.

What does it mean to be responsible for the ethics of your unit? First, you must *set an example* of moral values and standards of conduct:

- **Assume responsibility for the tough calls.** Don't ask someone else to take the fall when ethical obligations conflict or when they dictate an unpopular action. For example, if you need to let a popular employee go, take responsibility for the decision yourself.
- **Examine your own decisions for bias—publicly.** Model the questions you want others to ask. Laura Nash, who's considered business ethics from the perspective of both a consultant and an academic at Harvard Business School, suggests asking questions such as, "How would you define the problem if you stood on the other side of the fence? Whom could your decision or action injure? Are you confident that your position will be as valid over a long period of time as it seems now? Could you disclose without qualm your decision or action to your boss, your CEO, the board of directors, your family, society as a whole?"
- **Demonstrate genuine concern for *all* your company's constituencies.** Your economic duties to shareholders and investors don't erase the ethical responsibilities you have to customers, employees, suppliers, and the broader community. For example, if you supervise someone who brings in a lot of business but also sexually

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harasses the people they work with—even people outside your team—don't sweep their behavior under the rug.

Second, you must *ensure ethical behavior* among your team. That means scrutinizing individual decisions and actions, but also promoting an ethical culture at large. The two things are linked: in such a culture, people are proactive about testing their decisions against shared moral standards. They don't hide conflicts or ignore them until the conflict has become more material. Ethical thinking is a habit they take pride in.

The key to this culture is to encourage transparency around ethical issues. If you don't bring dilemmas out into the open, your employees develop distorted private beliefs about how everyone else is behaving. Maybe they think that no one else is struggling with these problems, and that ethical problems are actually ethical lapses that they should be ashamed of and conceal. Or maybe they think that *everyone* resolves ethical challenges in the same way: by breaking the rules when it's convenient.

You can counter this thinking by making it safe for people to tell you difficult truths. Your direct reports know things you don't. Tell them explicitly that you want to hear bad news and then reward those who come forward by listening without judgment and thanking them for speaking up. Then keep their information in confidence or acknowledge them publicly, as circumstances demand.

Your company likely has ethics guidelines that detail the code of behavior required of employees, and your company's general counsel can likely help with any potential legal implications. These codified standards are helpful, but what makes ethics so difficult is that not everyone has the same rules; our ethical compasses have been conditioned by our upbringing, our education, and the behavior we observe around us. You ultimately need to have your own compass for ethical issues. The fact that someone in your company tells you something is ethical doesn't make it so; even the fact that something is legal doesn't make it ethical. If your instincts tell you an ethical issue may be surfacing, consult with your boss or someone else in a leadership role as appropriate, to discuss your concerns and request guidance.

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Trust is the single most powerful tool you have to get work done. It's not a game you play with your employees, saying and doing the things you think they'll like. Instead, the actions you take to earn their trust genuinely transform you into the leader they need. Being mindful of your character, your competency, and your ethical standards is essential to your ability to earn credibility as a leader.

## Recap

- One of your first tasks as a manager and leader is to gain the trust of your team.
- You gain trust by consistently demonstrating character and competence.
- To demonstrate character, show that you value the team by giving team members a voice, recognizing them for their achievements, regulating your emotions toward them, and showing respect.
- To demonstrate competence, achieve quick wins but also underscore the credibility of your plans and ideas by citing your research and reasoning, and also by being frank about what you don't know.
- Authenticity helps make you trustworthy to the team that you lead. But beware of using authenticity as an excuse not to try new leadership approaches, even if they don't feel comfortable at first.
- Demonstrating ethical behavior is important to establishing your team's trust in your character, in addition to being a vital part of your role as a manager.

## Action items

- ☐ As you come into a new managerial role, identify three to four simple, well-defined problems that you can tackle as quick wins.

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- ☐ For your next team meeting, prepare a list of questions you can ask specific attendees. For example: “Dinesh, you’ve been the creative lead on this project for the past year. What have you and the rest of the team learned in that time that’s changed the way you approach the design process?” Use this type of questioning to involve team members in decisions or acknowledge their contributions.
- ☐ When you make your next big decision, clearly communicate how you’ve come to your conclusion—what research you’ve done, what factors support your choice, and so on.
- ☐ Use the box “Developing yourself as an authentic leader” to reflect on your background and experiences to better understand your own unique style of leadership.
- ☐ Make ethics a regular consideration in your decision-making process on your own and with your team. Pose questions like, “What ethical issues are at play here?” or “Who benefits from option A? What conflicts of interest do we have to consider there?”
- ☐ Practice owning your biases publicly, and invite other team members to do the same: “Cards on the table, I have a friend at vendor B, and I really respect her. That may speak well of the company, but it might be coloring my judgment, too.”





### 3.

# Emotional Intelligence

Since the idea of emotional intelligence (measured as “emotional intelligence quotient” or EQ) was introduced in the 1990s, it’s become essential to how we think about successful leaders. John Mayer, one of the psychologists who coined the term, defines it this way:

*[E]motional intelligence is the ability to accurately perceive your own and others’ emotions; to understand the signals that emotions send about relationships; and to manage your own and others’ emotions.*

This skill may be “soft” compared to, say, delegating or budgeting, but that doesn’t mean it’s unimportant. Research by Daniel Goleman, the author and psychologist who introduced emotional intelligence to management thinking, has shown that it is a more powerful determinant of good leadership than technical competence, IQ, or vision. EQ is now a criterion in hiring and promotion processes, performance evaluations, and professional development courses.

## CASE STUDY

### How to build emotional intelligence

Juan was a marketing executive for the Latin American division of a major integrated energy company. He was charged with growing the company in his home country of Venezuela as well as in the entire region, a job that would require him to be a coach and a visionary and to have an encouraging, optimistic outlook.

Yet 360-degree feedback revealed that Juan was seen as intimidating and internally focused. Many of his direct reports saw him as a grouch—impossible to please at his worst, and emotionally draining at his best.

Identifying this gap allowed Juan to craft a plan with manageable steps toward improvement. He knew he needed to hone his powers of empathy if he wanted to develop a coaching style, so he committed to various activities that would let him practice that skill. For instance, Juan decided to get to know each of his subordinates better; if he understood more about who they were, he thought, he'd be more able to help them reach their goals. He made plans with each employee to meet outside work, where they might be more comfortable revealing their feelings.

Juan also looked for areas outside his job to forge his missing links—for example, coaching his daughter's soccer team and volunteering at a local crisis center. Both activities helped him to experiment with how well he understood others and to try out new behaviors.

Juan was trying to overcome ingrained behaviors; his approach to work had taken hold over time, without his realizing it. Bringing them into awareness was a crucial step toward changing them. As he paid more attention, the situations that arose—while listening to a colleague, coaching soccer, or talking on the phone to someone who was distraught—all became cues that stimulated him to break old habits and try new responses.

Source: Adapted from Daniel Goleman, Richard Boyatzis, and Annie McKee, "Primal Leadership: The Hidden Driver of Great Performance," *Harvard Business Review*, December 2001.

While it's easy to dismiss emotions as something that doesn't belong in the workplace, managers and leaders benefit greatly when they are aware of their own emotions and those of the people around them and are able to demonstrate emotions with intention instead of reacting in ways that aren't thoughtful or productive. Goleman and his collaborators describe one such transformation in the case study described in the box "Case study: How to build emotional intelligence."

In this chapter, you'll learn how to nurture your EQ, especially the components of awareness and self-regulation. And you'll discover how to help your employees manage their emotions both individually and as a team.

## What is emotional intelligence?

Goleman describes emotional intelligence as a combination of five skills and traits that we start forming early in life and that ultimately form a core part of our personalities. By understanding each element described in the box "Emotional intelligence: five components," you can learn how to handle challenging or emotionally charged situations in the workplace with greater ease and better outcomes.

EQ isn't something you can measure objectively, but you can get a sense of your own perceptions of your strengths and weaknesses on each of these measures. (See the box "Questionnaire: Understand your perceptions of your own emotional intelligence" at the end of this chapter.) The more intentional you are in your understanding of and attentiveness to your EQ, the more emotionally steady you'll be in the workplace.

We'll look at a few of the components of emotional intelligence more closely in the rest of this chapter, focusing on two in particular: self-awareness and self-regulation.

## The power of self-awareness

Self-awareness means being observant and honest about your actions, feelings, and behaviors and how they affect those around you. To achieve this kind of self-knowledge, you don't need to be overly critical, but you do need

## Emotional intelligence: five components

### SELF-AWARENESS

#### *Definition*

The ability to recognize and understand your own moods, emotions, and drives, as well as their effect on others.

#### *Hallmarks*

- Self-confidence
- Realistic self-assessment
- Self-deprecating sense of humor

### SELF-REGULATION

#### *Definition*

The ability to control or redirect your disruptive impulses and moods. The propensity to suspend judgment—to think before acting.

#### *Hallmarks*

- Trustworthiness and integrity
- Comfort with ambiguity
- Openness to change

### MOTIVATION

#### *Definition*

A passion for work for reasons that go beyond money or status. A tendency to pursue goals with energy and persistence.

**Hallmarks**

- Strong drive to achieve
- Optimism, even in the face of failure
- Organizational commitment

**EMPATHY****Definition**

The ability to understand the emotional makeup of other people. Skill in treating people according to their emotional reactions.

**Hallmarks**

- Expertise in building and retaining talent
- Cross-cultural sensitivity
- Service to clients and customers

**SOCIAL SKILL****Definition**

Proficiency in managing relationships and building networks. An ability to find common ground and build rapport.

**Hallmarks**

- Effectiveness in leading change
- Persuasiveness
- Expertise in building and leading teams

Source: Daniel Goleman, "What Makes a Leader," *Harvard Business Review*, January 2004.

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to be realistic. Cultivating self-awareness is hard, because we often mask what's toughest for us to handle with emotions that feel safer.

To develop awareness around your behavior, identify patterns in the way you act on your feelings. When you feel angry, do you lash out or do you withdraw? When a task intimidates you, do you hang back or take over? Audit yourself briefly at the end of each day, for example, during your commute: What positive and negative emotions did you have today? When during the day did you feel effective, and what behaviors felt off? What do you think was driving your emotions and actions today?

You can ask yourself these questions on the spot, too—for example, after you lose your cool with an employee or when you ace an important task. Don't just focus on your problems; your successes have just as much to teach you.

Feedback from coaches, trusted colleagues, and even from your employees can help you gain perspective on what's going on, according to Goleman. How do they experience your moods and behaviors? A close friend or family member may be able to help you here as well, so consider reaching out: "I've been feeling really energized at work lately, and I'm not sure where the boost is coming from. Can you help me figure it out?"

Ideally, the reactions you observe in yourself will be *adaptive*, meaning that they will resolve the fundamental emotional problem you're facing. For example, you recognize that you're routinely impatient with one of your team members, so you adapt your approach to working with him to eliminate the frustration. But we all engage in some actions that are *maladaptive* and only make the situation worse. Classic maladaptive responses include:

- Procrastination
- Denial
- Brooding
- Jealousy
- Self-sabotage

- Aggressiveness
- Defensiveness
- Passive aggressiveness

The concept of pattern is important here. Everyone procrastinates sometimes. But as individuals, we tend to gravitate toward particular behaviors or thought progressions, our “go-to” reactions. If you regularly shut down during conflict, denial might be an important emotional pattern for you. Or if conflict usually causes you to cycle through the same thoughts over and over (“She’s *wrong*. I can’t believe she doesn’t see it! She made *one* good point, but mostly she’s just *wrong*”), you’re probably prone to brooding.

These emotional habits affect everything from our performance on a project to the impressions we make on our peers. But the patterns you’ve observed aren’t written in stone; they’re plastic. Once you become aware of any negative effect you have on others, you can adapt and mitigate the impact.

## Emotional steadiness and self-control

If you’re self-aware, you know when you’re angry. The next step is to use that self-knowledge to manage your emotions. This ability, which Goleman calls *self-regulation*, matters for three reasons.

First, your team reacts to your mood. A leader’s mood is communicable; your emotions color the experiences of everyone working around you. Goleman and his colleagues term this mechanism *mood contagion*. If you’re pessimistic and depressed, your team will be, too, even if it’s not their natural disposition. If you wear your stress on your sleeve for all to see, your team members will feel more stress as well. That’s because moods are transmitted at the physiological level through an open-loop system that involves hormone levels, cardiovascular functions, sleep rhythms, and immune functions. Our bodies respond involuntarily to these signals, and these distinct physical changes eventually combine in an all-encompassing emotional experience—good or bad.

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Second, emotional steadiness allows you to question or slow down your decision making in high-stakes situations, so that you don't make emotionally charged or ill-conceived choices. In today's business environment, the ability to keep a level head through rapid upheavals or long periods of uncertainty will serve you well.

Finally, your self-control underwrites your integrity. You need to be able to moderate your impulses so you can say no to ethical temptations that might harm your career or your organization. Impulsive actions don't need to be illegal to compromise your leadership; if you throw a contract to a friend, sleep with an employee, or even go back on your word to your team, you risk losing your employees' respect and confidence. Stress in particular can bring out the worst in all of us in the workplace. Self-control in highly stressed situations is invaluable.

### *Managing your hot buttons*

No matter how diligently you work to manage your emotions, you probably still have hot buttons—behaviors you're particularly sensitive to in other people or things you're personally touchy about. Maybe you loathe being interrupted, especially by a certain self-important colleague. Or perhaps you feel embarrassed about your public-speaking skills and poorly handle challenges to your ideas when you're giving presentations.

When you find yourself confronted by a hot button, you often can't contain the negative feelings it sparks. Perhaps you snap at the colleague who interrupted you, lose your ability to articulate your thoughts, or start to tear up in the middle of your presentation.

Business strategist and executive coach Lisa Lai suggests a three-part strategy for keeping calm in testy situations:

- **Acknowledge what's happening.** Put your self-awareness into action. Hot buttons always have a history. Maybe you react so poorly to being interrupted now because it was a major problem at your last job or in a personal relationship. Don't let those associations control you: recognize the history that's being triggered, but make a conscious decision not to project that past onto this situation.

You don't know how this moment is going to unfold.



- **Abstract yourself from the story.** What's happening feels personal; that's why it has the power to rile you. But what if it weren't? What if being interrupted wasn't a referendum on your worth or status, or about *you* at all? You don't know why your counterpart is behaving this way, and you don't have to play out their drama. So imagine you are watching this situation happen to someone else: what would be the best thing for them to do?
- **Develop a physical cue.** Heightened emotions take you deep inside your own head, but you can use your body to help redirect your thoughts. When you feel things escalating, make a subtle gesture or movement to anchor your focus firmly in the present moment. Lai herself presses her palms on the underside of a table or against each other; you can take a few deep breaths, hold a pen or other object firmly in your hand, or pick a place to fix your gaze for a few seconds while you gather yourself.

The good news is that you can recover even if you do snap at one of these triggers. If you do something you regret, acknowledge what happened. If you yelled at or humiliated someone in your outburst, start by apologizing. Then take a leap and explain what really happened for you: "I was angry and I'm not proud of how I acted. I've tried to understand what made me lash out like that, and I think I felt disrespected when you interrupted me." It's hard to wade back into the emotions that provoked your behavior in the first place. But research shows that people respond with heightened compassion and forgiveness when you appropriately disclose your emotions.

## Managing an employee's emotions

Just as good managers regulate their own emotions, they also monitor and react to the emotional states of the individuals on their teams. While you can't control how they feel or even how they choose to act, you *can* steer them in a more productive path. For example, if Pedro is pouting in a meeting about a new initiative, his disaffection may derail your team's support. But by working with Pedro to address his emotions and help him express

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them in a more positive way, you can defuse the tension in the meeting and better understand his point of view, perhaps learning something important in the process.

To do this, you must acknowledge an employee's emotional state, communicate that you value them as a person, and explain that you aren't willing to ignore inappropriate behavior. Then you can help them understand and solve the underlying problem. Here's how:

### ***Step 1: Spot the emotion***

Don't wait for the dam to break: watch for telltale signs, like a gap between what someone's saying and their body language—for example, if someone says they're on board with a decision but they avoid eye contact or get red in the face.

*You seem unhappy with this choice. Help me understand what you're thinking right now.*

### ***Step 2: Practice active listening***

Engage your employee to search for the issues that are motivating their emotional response. What can you infer about the facts this person is working with, about the values driving their reactions? What word choices and body language seem extreme, what phrases or ideas do they keep returning to? Follow up by paraphrasing what you've heard and asking open-ended questions about it.

*I can see this decision process has been frustrating for you. Help me understand. What's behind your frustration?*

### ***Step 3: Reframe your employee's emotions***

Use the information you've gathered to develop a hypothesis about what's going on, and then test it. If your employee is resisting a new training process, for example, do they not see its value, or do they believe it won't be well implemented? Make an informed guess and ask for their response. If you're right, your employee will feel heard; if you're wrong, their reaction will still teach you something useful.

*I'm hearing that you think this process will be inefficient, and you don't want to waste your time. Is that right? What am I missing?*

Once you've successfully completed this reframing, you can proceed with normal conflict-resolution techniques (see chapter 12, "Leading Teams").

This process may make your employee feel vulnerable, especially if it takes place in a group setting. The rest of the team may feel vulnerable, too, if they identify with their colleague's distress or if their colleague is attacking them. To get to a productive resolution, assure everyone that you're conducting this conversation in good faith.

#### **Step 4: Defend the team norms—gently**

Call out unacceptable actions, especially if other people are involved. The rest of your group needs to know that you take the rules you've all agreed on seriously, and that you have their back. But do so gently, with empathy for how the person is feeling; take into account how calling the employee out will affect him emotionally.

*I know you're frustrated, but sarcasm isn't helpful in a discussion like this. Can you restate your point?*

#### **Step 5: Offer an apology or sympathy if it's appropriate**

Sometimes what's going on with an employee is . . . you. Perhaps you did something inappropriate; maybe you unconsciously hit one of his hot buttons, or you might just be intimidating. When you acknowledge your own influence on the employee's emotional landscape, you signal that you're on his side and you want to help him resolve whatever's at the heart of his problem.

*I'm sorry I was dismissive when you first raised these concerns.  
I'm sorry that you're going through that in your personal life.  
I definitely don't want this issue to add to your stress right now.*

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These strategies will help your employees maintain their equilibrium in the moment and develop their emotional intelligence over time. You're helping them become stronger contributors to the group—and to your organization.

### **Building social awareness on your team**

Raising your individual employees' EQ will improve group dynamics, but you can also develop the emotional culture of your team as a whole by establishing a set of common expectations for how you'll interact every day, guidelines around how you'll all handle stress and overcome challenges, and rules about how decisions are made, according to Vanessa Urch Druskat and Steven B. Wolff, who, as researchers at Case Western Reserve University and Marist College, developed the theory of group emotional intelligence. These norms will help manage the group's mood, especially under pressure. A positive mood will, in turn, influence the motivation and productivity of each member of the team.

A handful of small, targeted interventions can have a big effect. Here are some suggestions:

#### ***Set ground rules—and stick to them***

- Call group members on errant behavior.
- Assume that undesirable behavior takes place for a reason. Find out what that reason is. Ask questions and listen, and avoid negative attributions.

#### ***Take time away from tasks***

- Gather for periodic outings outside the office to get to know one another.
- Have check-ins at the beginning of your regular meetings to ask how everyone is doing.

- Acknowledge and discuss group moods. Make time to discuss difficult issues and address the emotions that surround them.
- Express acceptance of team members' emotions.
- Support members by being flexible and offering emotional support or material help if they need it.

### ***When things get tough***

- Reinforce that the team can meet a challenge. Be optimistic. For example, say things like, "We can get through this" or "Nothing will stop us."
- Create fun ways to acknowledge and relieve stress and tension.
- Remind members of the group's important and positive mission.
- Remind the group how it solved a similar problem before.
- Focus on what you can control; focus on problem solving, not blaming.

### ***When making decisions***

- Ask whether everyone agrees with a decision.
- Ask quiet members what they think.
- Respect individuality and differences in perspectives.
- Validate members' contributions. Let others know they are valued.
- Protect members from attack. Never be derogatory or demeaning.

When you implement new rules, involve your team. Remember that you're not alone as a manager in trying to create a culture of self-awareness. Your team members are critical to the process. Consult the team as you create your ground rules, and make explicit compacts around language you will use to address conflict or break tension.

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Creating cultural change isn't easy, especially around emotions. But remember, you don't have to change the way people feel and think all at once. If you can tweak the way they *behave* even a little bit, the emotional stuff will follow on its own.

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Developing your emotional intelligence is work that will continue throughout your leadership journey. It's a foundational skill that underpins the leader's mindset: how you manage your own motivation and build relationships that support your goals; how you help your employees get better at their jobs; how you help many diverse personalities work together toward a common goal; and how you make the right business decisions under stressful, changing conditions.

### Recap

- Emotional intelligence is a more powerful determinant of strong leadership than technical competence, IQ, or vision.
- Emotional intelligence as Daniel Goleman originally defined it is a combination of self-awareness, self-regulation, motivation, empathy, and social skills.
- While you can't gauge your own emotional intelligence objectively, you can begin to get a sense for your perceived strengths and weaknesses through self-reflection and by getting feedback from trusted friends and family members.
- Your mood as a manager is literally contagious. Our bodies communicate stress, hope, and the like with others at a physiological level.
- Keep your cool in hot-button situations by acknowledging your triggers and then using thought exercises or physical cues to pull yourself out of the emotional whirlwind.

- Spot strong emotional reactions on your team before they bubble over. Help your employees articulate their reactions in productive ways by practicing active listening and reframing what you hear in language that will help all of you move on to normal conflict-resolution techniques.
- Promote positive emotions by defending team norms, offering an apology or sympathy when it's appropriate, and helping your employees save face after embarrassing outbursts.

## Action items

- ☐ Chart your emotional patterns by making notes in your calendar during each day or after a particular emotional episode. Then look for correlations. How do your moods affect your productivity and your interactions with colleagues? Do certain activities tend to fan emotional states like irritation or enthusiasm? Consider whether your reactions are adaptive or maladaptive.
- ☐ Check in with a colleague or friend and ask for feedback on your moods and behaviors.
- ☐ Think back to a recent conflict on the team. What were the turning points as things went south? Where were the key gaps in understanding? If the problem has been resolved, what actions made it better? Are there one or two explicit team rules that could have prevented the whole situation? Get input from key players or witnesses.
- ☐ Experiment with one or two new rules to solve a recurring problem with office dynamics—for example, your team's tendency to become pessimistic or fractious when they're under pressure. Explain why you're implementing this rule and set a fixed period of time for the test. During this time, press your employees to uphold the new rule; write it on the wall during meetings, include it at the bottom of emails, and uphold it carefully with your own actions. Then check back in with the group: Do they think it worked? How did it affect the group's dynamic?

QUESTIONNAIRE

Understand your perceptions of your own emotional intelligence

Great leaders move us—they inspire, motivate, and energize us. How? They do it through emotional intelligence. Dan Goleman woke us all up when he published his groundbreaking book on the topic (in 1995). Since then we’ve learned a lot about EI competencies, such as self-awareness and empathy, and about what people can do to develop them.

To gain a deeper understanding of your own emotional intelligence, respond to the statements in this questionnaire as honestly as possible, checking one of the columns from “Always” to “Never.”

To calculate your score, as you finish each section count the checkmarks in each column and record the number in the “Total per column” line. Multiply your total score for each column by the number in the row below it, and record it in the row below that. Add this row together to get your total score for how you perceive yourself along each of the dimensions of EI.

Reflecting on your strengths and where you can improve is important, but don’t stop there. Other people’s perspectives matter too. After reviewing your scores, ask one or two trusted friends to evaluate you using the same statements, to learn whether your own insights match what others see in you.

Source: Annie McKee, “Quiz Yourself: Do You Lead with Emotional Intelligence?” HBR.org Assessment, June 5, 2015. Questions adapted from the Hay Group’s “Emotional and Social Competency Inventory” and Richard Boyatzis’s article “Competencies in the 21st Century” (*Journal of Management Development*, 27:1 [2008], 5–12).



HOW WOULD YOU DESCRIBE YOURSELF?

|                                                           | ALWAYS | MOST OF THE TIME | FREQUENTLY | SOMETIMES | RARELY | NEVER |
|-----------------------------------------------------------|--------|------------------|------------|-----------|--------|-------|
| EMOTIONAL SELF-AWARENESS                                  |        |                  |            |           |        |       |
| 1                                                         |        |                  |            |           |        |       |
| 2                                                         |        |                  |            |           |        |       |
| 3                                                         |        |                  |            |           |        |       |
| 4                                                         |        |                  |            |           |        |       |
| 5                                                         |        |                  |            |           |        |       |
| Total per column                                          |        |                  |            |           |        |       |
| Points per answer                                         | x 5    | x 4              | x 3        | x 2       | x 1    | x 0   |
| Multiply the two rows above                               |        |                  |            |           |        |       |
| TOTAL SELF-AWARENESS SCORE (sum of the row above)         |        |                  |            |           |        |       |
|                                                           |        |                  |            |           |        |       |
| POSITIVE OUTLOOK                                          |        |                  |            |           |        |       |
| 6                                                         |        |                  |            |           |        |       |
| 7                                                         |        |                  |            |           |        |       |
| 8                                                         |        |                  |            |           |        |       |
| 9                                                         |        |                  |            |           |        |       |
| 10                                                        |        |                  |            |           |        |       |
| Total per column                                          |        |                  |            |           |        |       |
| Points per answer                                         | x 5    | x 4              | x 3        | x 2       | x 1    | x 0   |
| Multiply the two rows above                               |        |                  |            |           |        |       |
| TOTAL POSITIVE OUTLOOK SCORE (sum of the row above)       |        |                  |            |           |        |       |
|                                                           |        |                  |            |           |        |       |
| EMOTIONAL SELF-CONTROL                                    |        |                  |            |           |        |       |
| 11                                                        |        |                  |            |           |        |       |
| 12                                                        |        |                  |            |           |        |       |
| 13                                                        |        |                  |            |           |        |       |
| 14                                                        |        |                  |            |           |        |       |
| 15                                                        |        |                  |            |           |        |       |
| Total per column                                          |        |                  |            |           |        |       |
| Points per answer                                         | x 5    | x 4              | x 3        | x 2       | x 1    | x 0   |
| Multiply the two rows above                               |        |                  |            |           |        |       |
| TOTAL EMOTIONAL SELF-CONTROL SCORE (sum of the row above) |        |                  |            |           |        |       |
|                                                           |        |                  |            |           |        |       |

HOW WOULD YOU DESCRIBE YOURSELF?

|                                                 |                                                                                            | ALWAYS | MOST OF THE TIME | FREQUENTLY | SOMETIMES | RARELY | NEVER |
|-------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------|------------------|------------|-----------|--------|-------|
| ADAPTABILITY                                    |                                                                                            |        |                  |            |           |        |       |
| 16                                              | I'm flexible when situations change unexpectedly.                                          |        |                  |            |           |        |       |
| 17                                              | I'm adept at managing multiple, conflicting demands.                                       |        |                  |            |           |        |       |
| 18                                              | I can easily adjust goals when circumstances change.                                       |        |                  |            |           |        |       |
| 19                                              | I can shift my priorities quickly.                                                         |        |                  |            |           |        |       |
| 20                                              | I adapt easily when a situation is uncertain or ever-changing.                             |        |                  |            |           |        |       |
| Total per column                                |                                                                                            |        |                  |            |           |        |       |
| Points per answer                               |                                                                                            | x 5    | x 4              | x 3        | x 2       | x 1    | x 0   |
| Multiply the two rows above                     |                                                                                            |        |                  |            |           |        |       |
| TOTAL ADAPTABILITY SCORE (sum of the row above) |                                                                                            |        |                  |            |           |        |       |
|                                                 |                                                                                            |        |                  |            |           |        |       |
| EMPATHY                                         |                                                                                            |        |                  |            |           |        |       |
| 21                                              | I strive to understand people's underlying feelings.                                       |        |                  |            |           |        |       |
| 22                                              | My curiosity about others drives me to listen attentively to them.                         |        |                  |            |           |        |       |
| 23                                              | I try to understand why people behave the way they do.                                     |        |                  |            |           |        |       |
| 24                                              | I readily understand others' viewpoints even when they are different from my own.          |        |                  |            |           |        |       |
| 25                                              | I understand how other people's experiences affect their feelings, thoughts, and behavior. |        |                  |            |           |        |       |
| Total per column                                |                                                                                            |        |                  |            |           |        |       |
| Points per answer                               |                                                                                            | x 5    | x 4              | x 3        | x 2       | x 1    | x 0   |
| Multiply the two rows above                     |                                                                                            |        |                  |            |           |        |       |
| TOTAL EMPATHY SCORE (sum of the row above)      |                                                                                            |        |                  |            |           |        |       |
|                                                 |                                                                                            |        |                  |            |           |        |       |



# 4.

## Positioning Yourself for Success

In the previous two chapters, we've looked at the emotional and interpersonal skills you'll have to draw on to genuinely motivate your employees. But leadership is about more than having followers; you need somewhere to go. What does success look like for you—and for your team? How will you define that ultimate objective? As a manager, you need to think critically about your relationship to your organization's overall strategy and the opportunities you and your team stand to take advantage of.

In this chapter, we'll talk about shifting your mindset to think differently about success in your new role. You'll also learn about how to connect your own objectives and your team's goals with the organization's strategy, and how to identify and mitigate the risks that may stand in your way.

### Redefining success

As you transition from individual contributor to manager, you'll view problems and measure success in new ways. Your personal performance is no

longer the be-all and end-all: your primary responsibility now is getting things done through others. From this perspective, success is built on:

- Clearly defining expectations for your team members
- Meeting your team's targets and objectives
- Furthering the company's objectives through your group's achievements
- Honing your direct reports' skills and managing their tasks effectively

In other words, you succeed only when your group succeeds. Over time, you'll learn to find your team's accomplishments as satisfying as your own used to be. But it may take some time to achieve this sense of satisfaction, because you're further removed from the actual work than you were. As a result, your relationship to the outcome may feel distant, ambiguous, or even unrecognized. Coaching an employee may take months or even years to truly pay off. No one outside your team may ever see your amazing technique for running meetings. And when it comes to your unit's accomplishments, you'll rarely get the same instant gratification you got in the past with a successful outcome that was clearly your doing.

How can you still feel gratification under these changed conditions? Many managers learn to enjoy:

- Seeing and helping other people succeed and thrive in the workplace
- Discovering that they can be effective coaches who bring out the best in others
- Seeing themselves adapt to their new identity and master new responsibilities
- Developing compelling strategies and plans to achieve business targets
- Celebrating the success of your team when they meet their commitments

## Understanding your organization's strategy

As part of managing your team, you need to understand how you fit into the bigger picture. Your organization has an overarching plan for developing its competitive advantage, likely served by a series of cascading goals for business units and individuals. In chapter 15, “Strategy: A Primer,” you’ll learn more about how such strategies are created, but for now it’s only important to consider the expectations for your performance. As a manager, you work through your employees to support the company’s overall plan; your own strategies and goals must align with the priorities set from above. So as you make your own plans, clarify *what* you’re supposed to be delivering and *how* you’re supposed to do it.

### ***Step 1: Gather information about your strategic objectives***

In addition to reviewing any strategy documentation that your team, division, or organization may have, begin with a “listening tour”—a series of conversations with key figures in your organization that will help you clarify its strategic objectives. It’s obviously important to interview your boss, but you also want to understand the perspectives of other leaders in your group or organization.

But don’t just look up for answers. Consider coworkers below or lateral to you. You also want to hear from people with insight who may not have positional power to act on their ideas, but they will have a good read on what’s really going on. Who’s been at the company for a long time? Who’s worked closely with the current leadership? Who recently transferred from a company that went through a similar change process? For example, a peer in R&D might have niche knowledge about how technology in your field is likely to evolve, while someone in market research may have the most up-to-date information about how your customer base is evolving. Use the sample language in the box “Defining strategic objectives” as a template for these conversations.

As you conduct these conversations, press for clarity and specificity. “I hear you saying that innovation is a priority for my team. Where would you like to see us focus?” If open-ended questions aren’t getting you answers,

## Defining strategic objectives

### YOUR ORGANIZATION

- “What are the company’s major strategic objectives right now?”
- “What are the major needs/challenges/opportunities we’re facing over the next six months? Year? In the long term?”
- “I’m hearing that \_\_\_\_ is our primary priority right now, and that long term we’re preparing for \_\_\_\_\_. Am I reading the landscape right? What am I missing?”

### YOUR TEAM

- “How do you see my team fitting into this picture?”
- “What are your top priorities for my group? What are the big needs/challenges/opportunities you’d like to see us tackle in the next six months? Year? In the long term?”
- “I’d like to see my team do \_\_\_\_\_ and \_\_\_\_\_. What are your thoughts?”

### YOU

- “What role would you like to see me play in carrying out this strategy?”
- “What are the major needs/challenges/opportunities you’d like to see me take on in the next six months? Year? In the long term?”
- “I think I’d be most useful doing \_\_\_\_ and \_\_\_\_\_. What are your thoughts?”
- (With your boss or key peers) “What are *your* major objectives right now within the organization? How can I support them?”

offer limited choices: “I think there’s a lot of opportunity to innovate with the way we conduct client relations and with our inventory technology. Where would you like us to focus?”

Reflecting on your conversations, note the gaps and contradictions in what you’re hearing. Do different people emphasize different strategic goals? Is your supervisor tasking you with projects that don’t match the priorities she’s defined? If you can, press to figure out where these inconsistencies are coming from: “How do you see this special assignment supporting the overall direction you’ve sketched for my department?”

### ***Step 2: Analyze risk in your strategic objectives***

Once you’ve identified the goals and opportunities in front of you, also review all the information you’ve gathered and ask where the biggest risks are:

- What are the major sources of uncertainty in your team’s future?
- What *external* risks can you identify? Think about categories like funding; competition and conflict with other units in the company; the status of your patrons or protectors within the company; and potential reorganization.
- What *internal* risks can you identify? Think about upcoming personnel changes, team dynamics, and office politics.

Filter everything you’re learning through a more personal question, as well: What will it take for *you* to be successful in your role? This isn’t vanity on your part. Now that you’re a leader, your bosses expect you to be a strategic thinker, and that means learning to evaluate the risks and opportunities that you personally must navigate. Ask yourself these questions:

- What are the major sources of uncertainty in your own future?
- What *professional* risks to your success can you identify? Think about categories like your professional goals; your experience, training, and accreditation; your network, especially within

## 60 Develop a Leader Mindset

your company; and work logistics (for example, a difficult commute).

- What *personal* risks to your success can you identify? Think about your health, your family, your finances, and your personality and disposition.

Once you understand the major risks to your success, analyze them from a few different angles. First, which of these risks are most likely to have an impact on your success in a very direct way? What do you absolutely need to plan for? For example, if you know that your workload makes it hard to meet important deadlines—say, submitting legal filings to a court—you must find a strategy for dealing with this problem.

Second, which risks are impossible or impractical to counter? What *can't* you plan for? For example, you may not know if your company or division may be sold in the coming year, but if you haven't seen any indications of it, it may not be worth planning for. You can compensate for this risk by solving a related problem—say, planning for delays or creating new ways to strengthen your personal relationships with that team.

Third, which are easy to plan for? Are there high-value actions that would be easy for you to take? For example, if your inexperience with a particular coding language compromises your ability to lead a new product rollout, find out if your company will pay for you to take a course in the language or bring an expert in from outside the company.

Finally, who else in your organization do these risks touch? Who can be a strategic ally? For example, if your team needs expanded IT support to meet its performance targets, look for another unit in the company who's also underserved to help you press for more resources.

## Planning for strategic alignment

After all your research and reflection, it's time to make a plan for what you will do to be successful in this landscape. The goals you set should emerge from what you've learned about the overall strategy of your company and



your own position. The real power comes from aligning your goals with the highest purpose of the organization; ideally, every person you supervise will understand their individual goal, the goal of the unit, and how the unit's activities contribute to the organization's strategic objective. Draw on these questions to frame your goals:

- What metrics do you or your team need to meet to help the company succeed?
- What do you or your team need to provide to customers or customer-facing groups in your organization to achieve the company's vision?
- Which functional groups do you or your team work most closely with and how can you ensure alignment around shared priorities?
- What processes do you or your team need to excel at for the company to satisfy your customers and shareholders?
- What will you or your team need to learn and how will you or your team need to improve for the company to meet its goals?

As you start to make concrete plans, remember that you're tethered by your budget, staff, and schedule boundaries. If those parameters aren't clear to you now, start figuring them out. Which are absolutely immovable? Which are elastic? The better you understand your constraints, the more creative you can be within them.

Your answers to these questions constitute a list of action items. You've just defined the metrics you need to meet, the services you need to provide, the processes you need to excel at, and the improvements you need to make to be successful.

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Becoming comfortable with your new managerial identity involves some profound shifts in your beliefs, attitudes, and possibly even your values. As you begin to shift to a leader's mindset, you may discover—like many new

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managers—that aspects of the job you worried about or dreaded are actually fulfilling in ways you never expected. Whether you're earning the trust of a former peer or deftly handling an employee's emotional outburst, you'll develop competencies that are rewarding in and of themselves, in addition to making you stronger as a manager.

### Recap

- As you transition from individual contributor to manager, you'll view problems and measure success in new ways.
- You also need to understand how you and your team fit into the bigger picture of your organization and its objectives.
- By analyzing the risks that may threaten your achievement of these objectives, you can better position yourself for success.
- Define concrete plans about how you will achieve your objectives by considering the metrics you'll use, the groups you'll work with, and the processes and capabilities your team needs.

### Action items

- ❑ Using the questions from the “Defining strategic objectives” box, gather information by talking to your boss, colleagues, and other people whose influence or experience makes their perspective useful.
- ❑ Analyze the risks associated with your strategic objectives and consider how you might deal with each issue.
- ❑ Identify allies in your organization who are also affected and could help you going forward.
- ❑ Use the list of questions in the section “Planning for strategic alignment” to establish your own strategic goals that align your team's work with the organization's overall strategy.

- ❑ Practice recognizing—and savoring—success in your new role. Establish a ritual at the end of each week when you recall your achievements (and the achievements of your team) from the past five days. If it's all a blur, prompt your memory by looking at your calendar or doing a mental review of each day.

